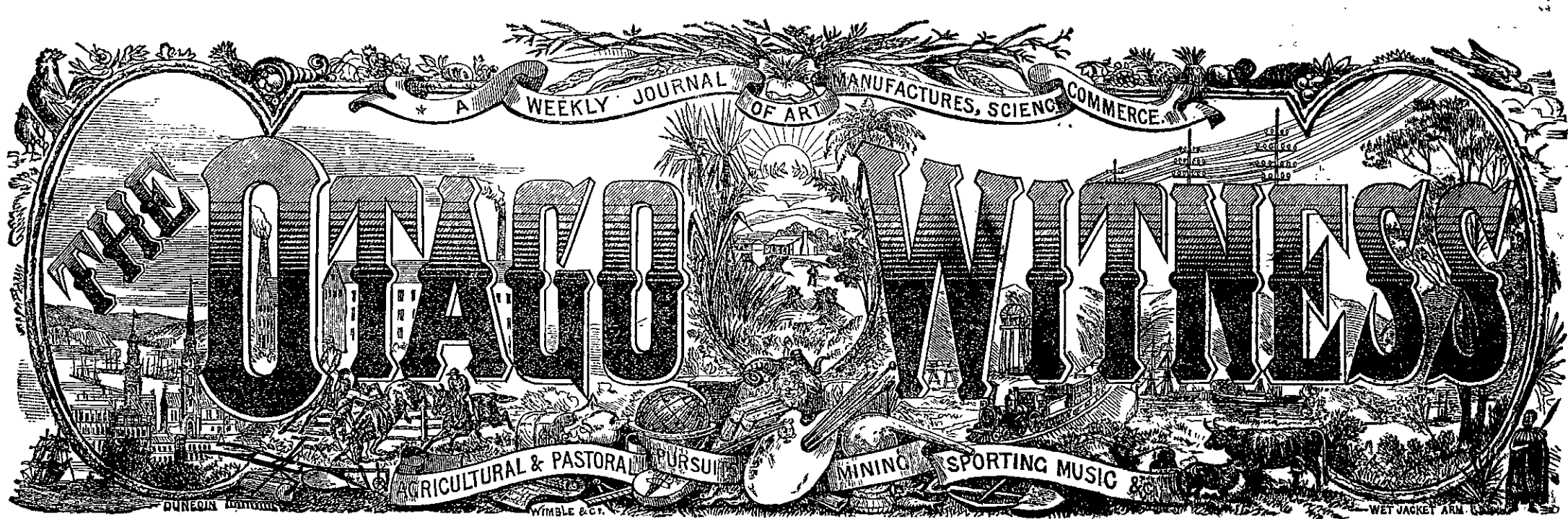




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DUNEDIN, N.Z., THURSDAY, AUGUST 18, 1892.

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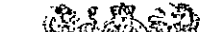
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THE SKETCHER.

PRECIOUS STONES AND GEMS.

Philosophers tell us that the taste for wearing trinkets is a relic of ancestral barbarism, and ardent democrats deplore the habit as subversive of equality, but, in spite of both philosophers and democrats, the love of precious stones appears ineradicable, and is now as widely spread as ever it was. Their beautiful colours and splendid scintillations of light make them most effective ornaments, while at the same time their rarity prohibits the multitude from obtaining them, and thus adds a double zest to the enjoyment of their fortunate possessors.

Pre-eminent amongst precious stones is the diamond, whose rays of flashing fire light up every assemblage of rank and beauty. Although not actually the most costly stone, it is by far the most popular, and only the immense annual supply from the South African mines and elsewhere prevents it from rising to fabulous prices. In ancient times India was the chief source which supplied the civilised world with diamonds, but in modern times India has been eclipsed by Brazil, and still more by South Africa in the present generation.

The latter mines are truly wonderful. In the midst of shaly rocks occur vertical pipes of what is known as "blue clay," which contain the diamonds. These pipes appear to be of eruptive origin as around them the shales are tilted upwards and outwards, and they continue downwards to an unknown depth. All the leading mines are close together, and are now operated by one company, the De Beers combination, and the annual output of diamonds is valued at nearly £3,000,000. The story of the discovery of these mines is very interesting:

A RICH FIND.

A Dutch Boer, named Van Wyk, who occupied a farmhouse at Du Toit's Pan, was surprised to find diamonds actually embedded in the walls of his house, which had been built of mud from a neighbouring pond. This led to examination of the surrounding soil, wherein diamonds were found. On deepening the digging, diamonds were still brought to light. Nor did they cease when the bed rock was at length reached. Such was the origin of the famous Du Toit's Pan. In July 1871 a fresh centre of discovery was reported at a small hill situated at only about a mile from De Beers, where a young man, having taken shelter from the sun under a mimosa bush, accidentally found a diamond by scraping the soil with his knife. A rush naturally ensued, and the surrounding town which, to meet the wants of the new-comers, sprang up with mushroom-like celerity, received the name of Kimberley, in compliment to the Earl of Kimberley, at that time her Majesty's Secretary of State for the colonies.

Many of the South African diamonds have a yellow tinge, which is considered an objection, but some are equal to the finest specimens from India. A remarkable feature of these mines is the unusual number of large stones. One of the most famous is the Stewart diamond, found on one of the river claims, and in the rough weighing 238 carats.

THE STEWART DIAMOND.

The claim from which the gem was taken was originally owned by a Mr F. Pepper, by him sold to a Mr Spalding for £30, and handed over by the latter to one Antoine, to work on shares. The claim was quite an outside one, and not thought much of by the owner, but as others were finding near him, he thought it was just possible he might also find a gem. He persevered until first, the "Fly Diamond," and next, after further toil, this prize rewarded his labour. Antoine's feelings when he first obtained a glimpse of the treasure may be better imagined than described. He says that he was working in the claim, when he told his boy to leave off picking in [the centre and commence at the side. Not being understood by the boy, he took a pick and began himself, when he was suddenly spell-bound at the sight of a large stone with the primary aspect of a diamond. For some minutes he could neither speak nor move for fear of dispelling the apparent illusion, but, collecting his energies, he made a dart forward and clutched the prize.

Quite of a different type are the diggings in Brazil. There we find no signs of the home of the stones like the De Beers mines, but they are found by washing the gravels, &c. Another point of contrast is that in Brazil large diamonds are extremely rare.

BRAZILIAN DIAMONDS.

The discovery of these precious stones in 1746 proved a great curse to the inhabitants on the banks of the diamond rivers. Scarcely had the news of the discovery reached the Government ere they tried to secure the riches of these rivers for the Crown. To effect this the inhabitants were driven away from their homes to wild, far-away places, and deprived of their little possessions. Many of them perished, but some were benevolently restored. Strange to say, on their return, the earth seemed strewn with diamonds. After a heavy shower the children would find diamonds in the streets and in the brooks which traversed them, and would often take home three or four carats of diamonds. Poultry, in picking up their food, swallowed diamonds, so that their viscera required searching before being disposed of.

Notwithstanding prolonged research, the origin of the diamond is still a vexed problem. Its optical properties led Sir Isaac Newton to predict that it would be found to be of vegetable origin, and many consider it to have been originally a gum. The rival theory is that it is formed by the action of volcanic heat on carbon in the earth, but the mode is quite uncertain, as unless oxygen were completely excluded, the volcanic heat would simply burn the carbon. The peculiar South African mines give some support to the latter hypothesis, as they are evidently eruptive. The recent discovery of diamondiferous matter in aerolites does not throw any additional light on this obscure question.

We have dwelt at such length on the diamond that we cannot devote the same space to the rest of Mr Streeter's book on "Precious stones and gems," from which we quote. The most beautiful of coloured gems, and the most valuable of all, is the ruby. We learn that a perfect ruby of 10 carats is worth 10 times a diamond of the same weight. But lest the possessors of ruby ornaments should rejoice too much, Mr Streeter informs us that spinels and garnets are very often sold as rubies, though comparatively worthless. The principal source of rubies is Burma, and the mines were kept jealousy hidden from European

eyes until the recent annexation of the country. Mr Streeter was a member of the syndicate which secured the working of these mines, and his description of them forms a most interesting part of the book. Before the British conquest all valuable stones were confiscated by the king, and no native was allowed to possess one of any size.

ROYAL CLAIMS.

In the reign of King Mindoon Min, a man working in a rice-field on a hillside found a large stone, which he handed to his wife's custody. One day soon afterwards a man named Gna Monk came by selling fish condiment; and as the woman had no cash she offered the red stone in exchange. The man recognising the stone as a ruby, gave her a rupee's worth of his goods, and carried off his treasure. He then broke the ruby in two presenting one-half to the king, and sending the other for sale to Calcutta. The king, discovering the fraud, ordered Gna Monk and all his fellow-villagers to be tortured. Learning that the missing portion was in Calcutta the king sent thither, and purchased the fragment for an enormous sum. It was then found that the two parts being fitted together formed one stone. The two portions were cut in Burma, one forming a large stone, weighing 93 carats, and named "Gna Monk," whilst the other weighed 74 carats, and became known as "Kallahpyan," signifying that it had returned from India.

The sapphire is really a blue ruby, but as it is much commoner it is not so costly. The new sapphire mines in Siam and Montana have been examined on behalf of Mr Streeter by special representatives sent out by him, and the substance of their reports has been incorporated in these chapters. So, also, has Mr Floyer's account of the ancient emerald mines of Egypt, which are now awaiting English enterprise to reopen.

The minor precious stones are very numerous, and are separately treated in brief sections.

Besides the actual mining, the process of preparing the gems for the market occupies large numbers of workmen. The diamond-cutters of Amsterdam are everywhere famous, perhaps few know that in some parts of Germany the dyeing of precious stones is an important branch of industry. Honey is largely employed for this purpose, and the following extract from S. Francis de Sales shows that its use has long been known:

HONEY AND BRILLIANTS.

All kinds of precious stones cast into honey become more brilliant thereby, each one according to its colour, and all persons become more acceptable in their vocation, when they join devotion with it. Household cares are thereby rendered tranquil, the love of husband and wife more sincere, the service of the prince more faithful, and all kinds of business more easy and pleasant.

Mr Streeter's book is worthy of its subject, for it, too, is a gem, beautifully printed and illustrated, and fit for a place on any drawing room table.

IF THERE WERE MEN IN THE MOON.

We must remember that in every fibre of our constitution we have been specially adapted to the life on this particular globe. We know how our senses are adjusted in harmony with the particular atmosphere in which the earth is surrounded; we have now to notice another point, in which the texture of our bodies is arranged to suit the material contents of this globe on which we dwell.

It may seem strange to learn that the strength of our bones and muscles has been adjusted not solely with regard to the size of our bodies or the quantity of matter they may contain, but with reference to the dimensions and mass of the earth. It might be, that on another globe, even though the atmosphere was exactly like our own both in density and in composition, even though it was supplied with water as ours is, even though it provided us with abundance of suitable food and had a climate agreeable to our constitution, yet it might be wholly impossible for us to exist there by reason of an incompatibility between the strength of our frames and the mass of the globe on which we stood.

Thus to take the case of the moon, which only weighs about one-eightieth part of the earth; the gravitation with which the moon would draw all bodies toward it would be much less than the similar gravitation on the earth. The weights of all objects would be reduced to about one-sixth part of that which we find them to possess here.

The buoyancy of our bodies would be so great that athletic feats would be easy on a body the size of the moon, which could never be attempted on this globe by beings with muscles like ours. If a man weighing 12st were to be transferred to the moon, the weight of his body, measured, at least, by the attraction which the moon would exercise upon it, would be reduced to about 2st. If his muscles and his frame remained the same, it would seem as if he would be able to jump over a wall 12ft high on the small globe without any greater exertion than would be required to clear a wall 2ft high on the earth.

Looked at from every point of view, it seems hardly possible that there can be any life on the moon resembling the life that we know of on the earth.—Good Words.

THREE NEW STORY-WRITERS.

The complaint is often made that it is much more difficult for a writer of average ability to gain a name to-day than it was 50 years ago. This complaint is just, in a measure, because of the remarkable increase in the number of persons who are able to write good English and who seem to have a passion for seeing themselves in print. This number grows every year in all English-speaking countries with the growth of newspaper and periodical literature. It has probably reached its maximum in this country, where the itch for scribbling seems universal. The magazine editors occasionally lift the veil, and give some idea of this mass of manuscript that descends upon them at all seasons. Neither midsummer heat nor mid-winter cold appears to have any effect in checking this output of manuscript. The same tale is told by the publishers of books and the long-suffering editors of newspapers. Ingenious devices are adopted to guard the editor from the personal visitation of ambitious amateur writers, but this is all that can be done in self-defence. Meanwhile, is it more difficult now to get literary recognition than a half a century ago? We think not,

but it is imperative to-day that one have something to say, which was not the case in the time of our grandfathers. The working over of historical and literary anecdotes furnished employment for a large number of people in the first half of this century. There was then a conspicuous absence in the manuals of every department of history, literature, and science, which are among the most noteworthy features of the book market of the period. In this country the situation was even worse than in England. Fancy in these days a man of Hawthorne's gift, who had already produced some of the best short tales in the language, spending himself on the preparation of Peter Parley's books for children and cyclopedias of universal history. Now, every enterprising publisher keeps a force of clever writers in his pay, and these men turn out handbooks at short notice in the best style. The whole field of useful knowledge has been exploited by what may be called the tribe of revampers, so that not one bit of undiscovered country remains. Under these conditions, it goes without saying that a man to secure a hearing nowadays must either devise some new thing or else he must put his old wine in bottles or in such novel design that they will attract the fancy.

Zola is right when he says that the novel is the great vehicle of the modern reformer. There is unconscious humour in the moral attitude of the author of "Nana" and "L'Argent," but it is a plain fact that the man or woman who wishes to reach the largest audience must appeal to it through a work of fiction. Most of the circulating libraries show that fiction is more widely read even than religious literature. The demand of the age is for amusement, as life is hard, and the pace is so much faster than that of 50 years ago that the great majority of people have neither the leisure nor the taste for the moral essays and the novels with a purpose which were once so popular. Hence the writer who can make one lose sight of the toil and worry of life is the favourite of the reader of the period.

In England several new writers of this class have come up within the past few years. First should be placed Hall Caine, whose works are few, but each is a masterpiece of sustained interest. "The Deemster" is probably his strongest work. We rebel against many things in it, but no reader can fail to be drawn powerfully toward this vivid picture of strange life on the Isle of Man, with its play of passion, its pathos, and its tragedy. Almost equally strong are "The Bondmen" and "The Scapegoat"—one a remarkable picture of the working out of the moral law in the frozen North; the other, a romance of Moorish life, in which the Jewish hero works out his moral salvation in a way that recalls the early prophets. No words can adequately describe the power of these stories. They are transcripts from a life that is utterly foreign to the reader, yet they hold the interest and appeal to the sympathy as though they were the reproductions of familiar experience.

Another writer who has much of Hall Caine's power of realism, though he works in an entirely different field, is A. Conan Doyle. His "Micah Clarke" first made him known to American readers. That stirring historical romance, however, cannot compare in interest and variety of character with "The White Company," recently published. It is an effort to reconstruct the Fourteenth Century, and it is not going too far to say that no man since Scott has so thoroughly brought out the character and the feeling of another age as Doyle. The gentle knight, his squire, his favourite archer, and all the other characters that move around him, are thoroughly in keeping with their time, and the reader may get a better idea from this story of the spirit of chivalry, than from any of the histories. This story as well deserves a place in the reading of any student of English history as Scott's "Ivanhoe" or "Kenilworth." Radically distinct from Doyle in his methods, but his equal as an artist, is the youngest of these three writers of romance—Arthur Quiller Couch, who until recently disguised his identity under the pseudonym of "Q." Of only one of his stories have we room here to speak, that superb romance "The Splendid Spur." It would be difficult to imagine anything more dramatic than the adventures of the young hero of this historical sketch. The light of a vivid imagination plays upon the scene, and stamps every incident upon the memory, while in detail, plot, dress, manners, and speech it reflects a past age as faithfully as Thackeray's "Esmond." In a time that is filled with hard realism, it is a pleasure to turn to such romances as those of Caine, Doyle, and Couch, for they rest the mind. In reading fiction, it is a good rule to get as far as possible from one's own environment, and any one who dips into the works of these three men will get that mental recreation which is a sovereign cure for depression—that enemy which lies in wait for the man who crowds too much work into one brief day.—American paper.

DOMESTIC JAPAN.

A SIMPLE AND REFINED PEOPLE.

Simplicity and refinement are the essential characteristics of life in Japan.

The houses, which are spacious, are constructed without foundations. Light wooden uprights resting on flat stones support the thatched or tiled roof. The walls, both outside and those which divide the rooms, are formed of latticed panels which slide over one another, or can be removed altogether if desired. These panels are filled with translucent paper. At night the house is closed in with wooden shutters.

The rooms, which are raised about a foot above the ground, are covered with soft padded matting kept spotlessly clean. In the centre of the living room is a shallow square pit lined with metal and filled with charcoal, for the purpose of cooking and warming, or the rooms are warmed with movable metal braziers.

There is no furniture present, no chairs, tables, beds, chests of drawers, pictures, or nicknacks. The matted floor serves alike for chairs, table, and bed. To keep it absolutely clean all boots, shoes, and sandals are left on the ground outside.

In one corner of the room is the raised recess or Tokonoma, where a vase containing a branch of a flowering shrub, and a hanging picture or kahemono, is always found.

The absence of furniture means the absence of many cares, and as two wooden chopsticks

and small lacquer bowls serve for all the purposes of eating, there is no need for plate glass, knives, forks, spoons, dinner services, and table linen. Thus life is simplified, though it loses, at the same time, none of its refinement; for no people can be more dainty and particular in their food, more neat and beautiful in dress, and more courteous and self-restrained in manner than the Japanese.

From babyhood all are trained to sit on the soles of their feet, and this is with the Japanese the attitude of repose. Kneeling thus on the floor, all work is done, and at night-time the padded quilts or futons are spread on the matting, and with one quilt beneath and another above sleep can be enjoyed as comfortably as in bed.

Before the evening meal is taken it is the invariable custom throughout Japan for every member of the household to take a dip in the family bath, which is heated to a temperature of 110deg to 120deg, at which heat it is found to be very refreshing.—The Hospital.

THE BERNADOTTES OF SWEDEN.

The ever entertaining "Politikos" has something to say about Sweden which will (says a Home paper) doubtless interest our readers:—

"In the lively town of Pau, romantically situated in the French Pyrenees, stands close by the Church of St. Jacques, a small grey one-storeyed unpretentious house. Over its door runs an inscription, and from it the traveller may learn that Charles Jean Bernadotte, who became in after years King Charles XIV. (John) of Sweden, was born in that house in 1763. A truly romantic history that of the Bernadottes, who, thanks to an historical accident, were raised from simple obscure burghers of Pau to be rulers of the finest kingdom of Northern Europe. But if mere chance raised them to this proud position, it was not mere chance that enabled them to retain it.

"What distinguished the Swedish Bernadottes, and distinguishes all their descendants, is their truly noble and loving family life, whence spring grand and beautiful human beings, ennobled by this, the only truly potent factor, education. It was at the little Court of Wied that Prince Oscar first saw the woman who has been to him a true help-mate and loving consort. His meeting with her is told in his poem 'Mon Repos,' the name of the Prince of Wied's family castle. In 1857, he led to his far mountain home his 'Angel bright and good,' the Princess Sophia of Nassau. A quiet, happy, retired life was that led by the young couple, the mother occupied with the cares of the baby boy who the following year came to charm their hearts and that of the delighted grandfather.

"Not long, however, could Prince Oscar then live the life of a simple burgher. In 1859 his father died, and his brother ascended the throne. As the new King was still childless, it fell to Prince Oscar to fill the role of Crown Prince, and undertake all the onerous offices of that post, from which he never was relieved until his brother's sudden and unexpected death, in 1872, placed the Crown upon his own brow. His poetic gifts hence had to rest a while, but only for a while. In intervals of business, in spare moments, Oscar Frederick is always ready to use his pen. His very real and simple piety, too, finds an outlet in his poems. The 'Easter Hymn' can be worthily placed beside any of the best Evangelical Church songs. A German translation of these poems was by the King's express desire dedicated to the then Crown Prince Frederick William (Frederick III) as 'the patron of works of peace and humanity.'

"When in 1872 the Duke of Oester Gotland (as Oscar Frederick was called till then) ascended the dual throne of Sweden and Norway, in his first address to his Riksdag he sketched the programme of the policy to which he has ever remained faithful. 'Like my noble predecessors,' he said, 'I, too, have decided to choose a device. I am deeply penetrated with the sense that the Royal Crown which has fallen to me as heir is not lent to me for mere outer splendour; rather, I know and admit that my responsible Royal mission, of which the Crown is the symbol, has been laid upon me to promote the welfare of the brother nations. These words be my motto, "Brodrafolkens Val." The device King Oscar chose for himself showed that he had realised of what nature would be his regal difficulties. Most earnestly, most conscientiously, has he striven to promote the welfare of the dual Scandinavian domain; but it has been no easy task, nor can it be said to have been crowned with entire success. The fault, however, is not the king's, it lies inherent in the character of the position, which presents an insoluble difficulty. Two nations have been artificially put together into harness whose past history and present aims are as far as the poles asunder.

"The one has a long and varied history behind it, full of warnings and lessons—a history that tells of doughty deeds as well as of deep humiliations; the other counts its generation as a people by but few decades. Add to this a difference of language, an intense mutual jealousy, a fundamental leaning on the one side to Conservatism, on the other to Radicalism, and we have some faint idea of the problem with which King Oscar has to deal. Thus one of the first acts of the Riksdag on his accession was to cut down his moderate Civil List of 900,000 rixdollars by 100,000, and it is well known that the king was crowned at his own expense.

"So far, King Oscar's earnest desire to be a union king has not been realised. It is, indeed, a difficult task to rule with three chambers, of which Sweden has two, and No way one, the latter country having by decree abolished the nobility and with it the Second House. That under these circumstances the king has never lost his personal popularity is almost marvellous, and yet so it is.

"By every means in his power King Oscar tries to get at the real requirements of his people. He travels much in the provinces, he interviews both public and private personages, he insists so far as in him lies on hearing the truth concerning all matters. He even often appears unexpectedly in the police courts to hear the trials himself, and frequently he exercises his Royal prerogative of pardoning if the offences be small. Since 1823 no Swedish king had availed himself of this right, and that such actions and many

others of a like peaceful nature endear him to his subjects can easily be understood."

THE ROOT-GRUBBER OF THE ALPS.

Usually the root-grubber is a man who has failed in other trades; perhaps an old soldier, or a day labourer who yearns for independence. Never a young man, generally one with grey in his hair.

When the mountain streams begin to swell and foam, he becomes restless, looks at the snowy heights, marks the return of the swallows, notes what flowers are opening in the meadows by the river. Then one fine day he dons his leather breeches and thick woollen stockings, puts on his heavy shoes with iron cramps in the soles, takes his spud and pick—comes into the kitchen, claps his old woman on the back, and says, "So! the time is come. You will not see my brown face again till the first snows, and then it will be 10 times browner—like your coffee berries. Now, old wife, you know what I want up in the heights."

She nods. She has it ready—a supply of flour, salt, bread, and a bottle of holy water. He would go without bread rather than without this latter.

The root-grubber is careful to provide himself with something besides pick and spud—and that is a rifle, for when in the mountains he relies for his food to some extent on the chamois he can kill.

He builds himself a little hut high up of interwoven branches of pine, roofed with bark held down by stones. Here he kindles his fire, cooks his food, and sleeps. The hovel is destitute of every convenience, is pervious to wind and rain, and is not calculated to endure beyond the summer. But the situation is magnificent. The richest verdure clothes the slope on which it is planted, and the snowy peaks and glittering glaciers surround it. The air is musical with the bells of the pasturing cattle.

He cares little enough apparently, for the beauties of nature—his object in life is to find roots, especially those of the gentianella, that which is dark blue and the rarer yellow gentian. Formerly, when the Gentiana acutis starred every green sward, his labours were not arduous nor perilous. But as the Alps have been rifled, the flowers have to be sought on spots hitherto unexplored, and for this purpose the man must tread hardly a goat can find foothold.—Cornhill Magazine.

THE GHOST OF PILATE.

A LEGEND OF MONT PILATUS.

There are many legends connected with Mont Pilatus. One—and, of course, it is only a legend—tells how, after our Lord was crucified, Pontius Pilate, having in some way offended the Emperor Tiberius, was summoned to Rome to answer for his offence. In order, however, to withstand the wrath of the Emperor, Pilate had recourse to an amulet, and it is said that on every occasion when he came into the presence of the Emperor the wrath of Tiberius disappeared.

At length, however, his enemies suspected that he possessed some charm concealed about his person, and it is said that they discovered beneath his toga (the ordinary garment of the Romans) the robe of Christ. He was at once deprived of the sacred garment, and taken before the Emperor, who condemned him to death. His body was flung into the River Tiber, but violent storms arose, so the frightened inhabitants determined to banish him to the lonely heights of Mont Pilatus, where his body was cast into a black, sluggish tarn, or lake.

From this time the mountain and lake, according to the legend, became haunted, and violent storms constantly took place. One day a student happened to arrive at Lucerne, and hearing the strange tales of the mountain, and on being promised a heap of gold, agreed to climb the haunted mountain and make terms with the supposed ghost of Pilate. It is said that after a deal of bargaining the spirit of Pilate leaped into the lake, having first entered into a solemn treaty that he would only reappear on Good Friday unless stones were thrown into lake, or in the event of disrespectful words being spoken of him in its neighbourhood, in which case the usual penalty of thunder, lightning, and terrific storms would ensue.—Little Folks.

ALONE ON THE "ISLE OF SKULLS."

On the lonely, wind-swept island of San Nicolas, 80 miles off the coast of Ventura county, California, where, as far back as the memory of man runs, hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillsides, local archaeologists are now busy gathering the relics of a strange extinct race. The island is 10 miles long and oval in shape, being four miles across at the widest part. Strange utensils of sandstone and statite are found there among the human bones, and the island and its erstwhile inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1835 the priests of Santa Barbara learning that there were but sixteen of the strange Indian race then living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and one of the frequent storms of the channel islands springing up, the sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks of Point Conception and all on board were lost.

Sixteen years later Captain George Nidever and two men went from the coast on a sloop to hunt over off San Nicolas. On landing they were like Crusoe, astonished to discover human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea.

It was two years thereafter that the adventurous captain, revolving in his mind the right of the footprints in the uncanny island, determined to go and discover and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him, and at length they saw on the surf-beaten shore a woman with long tawny hair, dressed in a queer garb of coloured birdskins, and scraping with a bone knife the blubber from a seal.

They surrounded and approached her stealthily, and although suddenly confronted she did not appear in the least afraid, but smiled, and then falling on her knees, prayed to the sun. The wild woman offered no ob-

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jection when by signs she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat.

They reached Santa Barbara across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr S. L. Shaw, now 80 years old, and yet living there, riding a horse. She had never seen or heard of any object like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterwards the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed San Nicolas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race for ever.

Wild dogs had eaten her child. Her dress of blue and red feathers, a wonderful creation of barbaric hands, were sent to the Pope of Rome. Relic hunters have gathered mortars, pestles, toy steatite, canoes, and other curious things there for some years past, and shipped them to various Eastern and European museums. Skeletons and parts of skeletons have also been collected in large numbers, but to-day the bones of thousands of Indians are scattered about there. Some lie face down, indicating that they have fallen in battle. There are so many human relics there that San Nicolas is known as the "Isle of Skulls."

"The lonely island, whose highest part is but 1040ft above the sea," said a resident of Ventura, "is noted for the high artistic class of many of its relics. Had the woman rescued, then 52 years old, not died, a story passing strange would no doubt have been told of the race so long hemmed in by the waste of waters about. As it is, much of the story is shrouded in mystery for ever."

SOME DANGEROUS SUPERSTITIONS.

Quaint and grimly amusing are some of the beliefs and practices which we still find clustering round the dread presence of Death. Omens and "tokens" are articles of faith almost everywhere, and it is astonishing to find how many people, who really know better, allow themselves to be influenced in this way. There is scarcely anyone, in all probability, who has not met with something of this kind, and the misfortune is that in many cases the so-called "warning" largely assists in bringing about its own fulfilment.

These omens are very various. In Wiltshire, if the clergyman makes a mistake when reading the prayers there will be a death within the week. "Our parson made a slip this morning," an old lady was overheard to say as she was leaving the church. "I wonder who 'twill be this week." In Northamptonshire, a similar result is expected if the church clock strikes while a "passing-bell" is being rung.

In the south, every remnant of Christmas decoration must be removed before Candlemas Day. Should a sprig of holly or other evergreen be left on any pew, one of its occupants will die within the year. In Wales the miners, or at least some of them, consider it a sign of death to meet a woman when going to their work in the morning. Less than 20 years ago a woman was employed as a messenger at a North Wales colliery, and was often very early at her post. In this way she was frequently met by the men, who ultimately held a meeting and demanded her dismissal, threatening an immediate strike if their request was not complied with. A similar belief is to be met with in parts of Yorkshire. Quite recently a young lady visiting one of the prettiest villages in that county rose early one morning, proposing to take a walk before breakfast. Her hostess, however, begged her not to go out, as every collier on his way to a neighbouring pit would, if he met her, at once return home, and so lose his day's work.

If a hen neglects her legitimate business of laying eggs and takes to crowing, or if her lord and master is uneasy and crows at midnight, there will shortly be a death in the owner's family. The same result will follow in Kent if anyone catches and keeps a sparrow, if a sick man asks for a pigeon, or if bees swarm upon rotten wood.

In Northamptonshire the sight of three butterflies at once sends dismay into many a heart, and a bird entering the house by means of the chimney is a visitor more to be dreaded than the tax collector.

In most parts of the country a dog cannot enjoy the luxury of a long, melodious howl without causing much trepidation, for it is supposed that he has seen death enter the house, and is unhappy in consequence. In some parts of Nottinghamshire death is supposed to enter the house in the shape of a little black dog. Only a year or two ago a lady of fair social position, whose husband was dangerously ill, absolutely abandoned hope because a strange black dog walked in at an open door and made a tour of the house. It was only when it was proved that the animal was an earthly acquisition of a neighbour that renewed efforts, fortunately successful, were made to save the man's life.

The privilege of a special private "warning" is enjoyed by many families. It is only very "old families," however, that are thus honoured, and the possession of what may be called an hereditary omen is a certain mark of respectability. The Clifton family, who for at least 700 years have made their home by the banks of the Trent, are warned of approaching doom by a huge sturgeon forcing its way up the river, while two gigantic owls, perched on the battlements of the family mansion, convey similar warning to the noble house of Arundel.

When a death has occurred in the family of a well-known earl, some one has always seen or heard a spectral drummer, beating an apparently material drum up and down the house, and many a labourer on a certain Cheshire estate will testify that huge trees may be seen floating on the lake near the hall, for many a night before the death of a lord of the manor. In days gone by, the Oxenham used to see a bird with a white breast fluttering in the sick chamber before the death of any member of the family, and the spectral vision of a Benedictine nun warned the Roman Catholic house of Middleton of approaching dissolution. Outside our own country the celebrated "White Lady" who foretells the death of members of the royal race of Hohenzollern has attracted the notice of many writers.

In Devonshire, as the hour of death approaches, every door, drawer, and box in the house is unlocked, as anything fastened would hinder the flight of the spirit.

In Gloucestershire the door is opened at death to permit the passage of the soul. For some reason best known to the good west country folk, the windows must be kept closed, lest perchance the soul should find its exit by their means. Quite recently a coroner, finding the room wherein the dead body lay quite "stuffy," ordered the windows to be opened. The widow, who was present, protested emphatically. "What," cried she, "will you let the poor man's soul fly out of the window?" and with her back to that source of light and ventilation she defied the coroner and all his men. It is interesting to note that the exact contrary of this custom is to be met with in Norway, where all the windows are thrown open to facilitate the upward flight of the spirit.

In the west again, a lingering painful death is eased if dust, gathered from the floor near the altar, be sprinkled on the bed. A family, watching at the bedside of one of their loved ones, were interrupted by the old lady who acted as sexton, bringing them a carefully wrapped packet of this precious dust "to help the poor soul to go."

When death has actually occurred the bees must be informed and a piece of crape placed on the hive. If the body remain flexible there will be another death in the family within 12 months. In Warwickshire, when the funeral cortege leaves the house, the door must not be closed until its return, or another death will occur very shortly. When the corpse reaches the churchyard it "must go w' the sun" no matter how great the detour.

Extraordinary convulsions of Nature, we are told, sometimes mark the exact moment of death, and even inanimate objects are mysteriously affected. Some years before the dawn of the "Ta-ra-ra" epoch, our asylums were tenanted by people who were constantly reiterating the history of a certain clock, which, after going "Forty years without slumbering"—Stopped short, never to go again, when the old man died.

A near relation of this "Grandfather's clock" is to be met with at Grimsthorpe, where there is a timepiece belonging to Lord Willoughby d'Eresby, which formerly stood in the House of Lords. It bears a curious memorandum from the king's clockmaker to the effect that it stopped, without any apparent cause, at the exact moment when George III expired. It was not out of order, nor did it want cleaning in any way, for upon being set going again it continued all right until Parliament was dissolved.

In conclusion, it may be necessary to say that these survivals from a superstitious age are not recommended for approval or adoption. On the contrary, it is hoped that the wide publicity now given may deal some of them a blow from which they will not recover.

PEOPLE WHO NEVER GO TO BED.

A man charged with begging once declared that he had not been in bed for 13 years; he took his rest in doorways and passages. This is not a bad record; but many of the homeless class could probably beat it. Certainly there are thousands—not only in England but all over the world—to whom such a luxury as a bed is unknown; unfortunates obliged to lay their heads in the oddest places imaginable to prevent their being rudely awakened by the police. A sad never-does well told the writer that this was his principal thought for more days than he could count: Where should he sleep that night? And he had a theory that but for having this object constantly in view as he tramped over the monotonous pavements of London he must have lost his reason. He laughed himself in after days when he thought of some of his experiences at "dossing out." Even he, however, never slept in a stream, which was what some 30 persons of both sexes did at Buda Pesth a few years back. The water, which was warm, flowed from a mill, and the vagrants got into it and converted a number of stones into temporary pillows.

Even people with homes could tell some strange stories on this head. Of course, in some countries beds are unknown. The Japanese, for example, sleep on the floor, muffled in a great wadded coat, and with a block of wood for a pillow. But, confining ourselves to England, just talk to the dwellers in the slums on this subject. Why, going to bed there during the summer months is positively inviting torture! Many places swarm with vermin, and consequently those who live in them find it more comfortable to sleep anywhere rather than in the proper place—even on the doorstep.

Do "trippers" ever sleep, except in railway carriages, and do holiday-makers sleep anywhere when they are at certain of our popular health resorts? The manager of an Isle of Man hotel remarked a few months ago that "visitors" never went to bed. His servants were often asked to provide breakfasts at 3 or 4 a.m. Certainly the streets of Douglas are pretty lively any time during the season. A gentleman is fond of relating that one night a select party settled not far from his bedroom window and created the most discordant din imaginable. He bore it with exemplary patience for about five hours, and then, dressing himself, he went out and mildly expostulated, saying he wanted some sleep. "Sleep!" roared one of the gang, blowing a terrific blast on a toy trumpet. "Then what did you come to the Isle of Man for?"

They say at Blackpool, too, that if you arrive at any hour of the day or night you are just in time for something or other. The story goes that early one morning a dance was in progress on one of the piers, when a shipwrecked sailor, who had been drifting about on a spar, and had fortunately "landed" on the piers below, crawled up the steps. The M.C. came forward—they are never surprised at Blackpool—smiled, bowed, and said, "Pleased to see you, sir. Can I find you a partner?"

CATTLE TRAILS OF THE PRAIRIES.

The most famous of these was the "Chisholm Trail." It was named after John Chisholm, an eccentric frontier stockman, who was the first to drive over it. From 200 yds to 40 yds wide, beaten into the bare earth, it reached over hill and through valley for over 600 miles (including its southern extension) a chocolate band amid the green prairies, uniting the north and south. As the marching hoofs wore it down and the wind blew and the waters washed the earth away it became lower than the surrounding country, and was

flanked by little banks of sand, drifted there by the wind. Bleaching

SKULLS AND SKELETONS of weary brutes who had perished on the journey gleamed along its borders, and here and there was a low mound showing where some cowboy had literally "died with his boots on." Occasionally a dilapidated waggon frame told of a breakdown, and spotting the emerald reaches on either side were the barren circle-like "bedding grounds," each a record that a great herd had there spent a night. The wealth of an empire has passed over the trail, leaving its mark for decades to come. The traveller of to-day sees the wide trough-like course, with ridges being washed down by the rains, and with fences and farms of the settlers and the more

CIVILISED REDMEN intercepting its track, and forgets the wild and arduous life of which it was the exponent. It was a life now outgrown, and which will never again be possible. Once started, it was remarkable the orderly manner in which a herd took its way across the plains. A herd of 1000 steves would string out to a length of two miles, and a larger one still longer. It made a picturesque sight. The leaders were flanked by cowboys on wiry Texas ponies, riding at ease in great saddles with high backs and pommels. At regular distances were other riders, and the progress of the cavalcade was not unlike that of

AN ARMY ON A MARCH. There was an army-like regularity about the cattle's movements, too. The leaders seemed always to be especially fitted for the place, and the same ones would be found in the front rank throughout the trip; while others retained their relative positions in the herd day after day. At the start there was hard driving, 20 to 30 miles a day, until the animals were thoroughly wearied. After that 12 to 15 miles was considered a good day's drive, thus extending the journey over 40 to 100 days. The daily programme was as regular as that of a regiment on the march. From morning until noon the cattle were allowed to graze in the direction of their destination,

WATCHED BY THE COWBOYS in relays. The cattle by this time were uneasy, and were turned into the trail and walked steadily forward eight or 10 miles, when, at early twilight, they were halted for another graze. As darkness came on they were gathered closer and closer into a compact mass by the cowboys riding steadily in constantly lessening circles around them until at last the brutes lay down, chewing their cud and resting from the day's trip. Near midnight they would usually get up, stand awhile, and then lie down again, having charged sides. At this time extra care was necessary to keep them from aimlessly wandering off in the darkness. Sitting on their ponies, or riding slowly round and round their reclining charges, the cowboys passed the night on sentinel duty, relieving one another at stated hours.—Scribner's Monthly.

PATER'S CHATS WITH THE BOYS.

The Planet Mars. Last week's Witness contained some very interesting notes on Mars, but there are still one or two points of interest in connection with our brilliant visitor that have not been referred to.

Its day is rather longer than ours, being 24hrs 37min, while the length of a year extends to 687 days. A peculiar thing about the poles is that they are not exactly opposite each other. The seasons, too, are very unequal. Spring has 192 days, autumn 150, summer 180, and winter 147. It has two satellites or moons. Deimos (Terror) is about 13,000 miles from the surface of Mars, and revolves round it in about 30hrs 18min, while Phobos (Fear) is only about 4000 miles from the surface, and revolves round its mother planet in about 7hrs 39min or three times a day, while our moon takes a month to perform one revolution. To us, two moons, one revolving so rapidly and so close to the earth, would be, for a time at any rate, rather an uncanny sight, but the good folk, if there are any on Mars—and we should we suppose our puny planet is the only one of the solar system inhabited?—are of course used to it. There is, however, no moonlight in the Arctic regions of Mars, for the moons revolve round the Equator and so close to it that its curve shuts out their light from the poles. To see Phobos one must not be more than 69deg away from the Equator. Have you read Gulliver's Travels? In the voyage to Laputa Swift announced that the astronomers had found two satellites to Mars, and they also discovered that one revolved in 10 hours. It isn't long since that both statements would have been laughed at as astronomical truths. These guesses of Swift's (there's that possessive!) were certainly extraordinary.

Prohibition. Some of my critics could not have read my notes on Prohibition, or they would not have written as they have. I said distinctly that the time was not ripe for Prohibition, but that it was only by striving for an ideal that an approximate could be gained. In discussing this question we must bear in mind three points. (1) Is the liquor traffic an iniquitous one? (2) Ought compensation to be paid for suppressing an iniquity previously sanctioned by law, when public opinion has been for years gradually lining up against it? (3) If we are to have universal suffrage is the majority to rule or not? Public opinion has, since 1880, been working towards Prohibition, and in that way has been declaring that the traffic is an evil which, though sanctioned by law, has been threatened with suppression since 1880. It seems to me that publicans from a purely business point of view ought to have looked ahead and converted their properties into accommodation houses pure and simple, or business places. To my mind equity does not demand compensation for the suppression of what public opinion is declaring to be an iniquity; and if one-man-one-vote is the law, the majority must rule.

If any of you feel sufficiently interested to read up the speeches given on the subject in Parliament send to the Government Printer, Wellington, for the No. 5 issue of Hansard.

The main reasons given in favour of compensation were:

1. Publicans are deprived of their licenses because irresponsible bodies (why "irresponsible" when they represent a majority?—Pater) have the power of saying the house is not required.—Mr Lawry.
2. Licenses are annually renewable for a reasonable period.
3. The act passed some years ago was not intended to be used to suppress the drink traffic.—Mr Fish.
4. Prohibition is taking away the living of honest men pursuing a trade sanctioned by law.—Mr Fish.
5. The law requires a man to build a house according to regulations before a license is granted.—The act.
6. Committees closing all hotels are biased.—Mr Fish.
7. Compensation was given when slavery was abolished.

The opinions of several eminent men including John Ruskin—"I'll concede compensation to-morrow if publicans will live up to Ruskin's teaching—are pressed into service, but I'll not quote them because eminent men have spoken for Prohibition too. The points I have given rest on fact or equity, and are not to be settled in the same way as, say, Protection or Free-trade. Now for replies to the arguments advanced:—

1. If the people are competent to return members to the House to deal with the high interests affecting the destinies of this country, they are perfectly competent to elect licensing benches to deal with such a comparatively small matter affecting the country as the administration of the licensing laws.—Mr ALCOCK.

2, 3, 4, 5.—Since the passing of the act in 1880 there has been an acknowledged insecurity of tenure and the act was intended, by the prime movers in passing it, to act in the direction of Prohibition, and as I wrote before, anyone holding or buying hotel property has—at least since the last act was passed, if not before—been alive to the risk run. It has been and is still a business risk pure and simple. The less said about taking away an honest man's living the better. Many are honest, but the vast majority of hotels are drinking dens, and their keepers know it. (A New Zealand Judge (Mr Justice Richmond) says:—"If I have their minds made up upon this question is to have a bias, then the Legislature has advisedly provided for the appointment of judges with a probable bias, and no one can complain that they are what the statute means they should be."—Are not all men biased who contest elections?—PATER.)

The fact of compensation being awarded when slavery was abolished has been made a great deal of; but in that case property was absolutely forfeited. In closing public houses as drinking saloons, they are not closed to the true use of a hotel—viz., as accommodation houses. Spirituous liquors are not a necessity with a meal or bed. But was the payment of compensation for the liberation of slaves one demanded by equity? I think not. The slave holding was an iniquity, and should we pay to abolish what the majority think is iniquitous? Certainly not, especially when repeated warning has been given of the gradual but certain change of public opinion.

Compensation to slaveholders was not given because of the justice involved but because the Parliament then was legislating for the upper and middle classes, who were so directly interested in the land and in the products of slave labour, and the compensation came largely from taxes levied on the masses, who were not represented in Parliament. We are legislating now under different conditions. Again, it was not such a long time before the liberation of slaves that England had lost her American colonies, and followed up the War of Independence by a war with the United States just before Waterloo. When the £20,000,000 was voted there was a feeling of discontent in the West Indies, and the United States would only have been too glad had the Indies rebelled. It was deemed politic then—not necessarily equitable—to give the planters a sum to cover losses.

I have, I think, written sufficient on the subject. Effectual Prohibition cannot be got yet; but because we cannot attain to the ideal, that is no reason why we shouldn't approximate to it, and I ask my young friends not to be swayed by sympathy, but to face the question fairly. Is the liquor traffic a curse to the country? Does the suppression of an iniquity demand compensation? We now have one-man-one-vote. Are, then, majorities to rule or not? Answer those questions without quibbling, and act accordingly.

Here is "A B C's" letter. It will be seen that the writer supposes that wholesale houses will be allowed to flourish when hotels are closed up—that men must be allowed to make beasts of themselves. Reformers don't intend to allow either. "A B C" forgets, too, that all great reformers "see only in one direction." The complaint at the end is rather a left-handed one, but as I like candour I have taken the trouble to decipher the hieroglyphics of my correspondent, and recast the letter to make it "read"—I won't do it again though for anyone—so that the compositor shall not be tempted to use too forcible English.

DEAR PATER, I have read your article in last week's Witness about Prohibition. You wish your readers to write what they think about the matter. I think your ideas are rather narrow about publicans in general and compensation. In the first place, hotels in the proper sense of the word are a great convenience to the public, and it costs a lot of money to fit one up as it should be. What sane man would build such a place for only one or two years' license? So long as a hotel is conducted in a proper manner it is cruelty to take away or refuse the license through the influence of energetic fanatics without some sort of compensation—say a half or two-thirds compensation—[how calculated?] for closing such places, if it is thought necessary to interfere with the hotel-keeper's livelihood. As for men's drinking habits, I believe the so-called temperance people know very little of human nature. To me they resemble a horse with a pair of blinkers on—they only can see in one direction, and that not always the right one. I have known many cases in the country districts of Otago as well as Australia, where men having, say, £10 or £20 to spend, spend it they would, and if the hotel-keepers would not let them and their companions get drunk and spend their money what, think you, would these men do? Why, send to the nearest wholesale spirit merchant for, say, 2gal of one liquor and 2gal of another, and carouse in their own huts. As a consequence, they drink five or ten times more grog than if they got it at a hotel, where it is well watered. Which are the most likely to get the D.T.s?

Please excuse this scrawl, as it is now past time. Allow me to say I read your chats as a rule with great relish when upon geography and history. A B C (Goldfields).

—Of the 657 existing kinds of reptiles, 400 species are harmless.

OUR LITTLE FOLKS.

By Dor.

Do not be pleased to receive short letters from juvenile correspondents on any matter of interest to themselves—short stories of put animals, descriptions of their favorite toys, their parties, amusements, &c. The letters to be written by the children themselves, and addressed "Dot, care of the Editor," and to be published in the page devoted to "Our Little Folks."

A GOOD THOUGHT.

(Written for the Witness Little Folks, by "Allico.")

(Continued.)

"Willie's rug was destined to be a source of never-failing pleasure to him. It seemed to him more like a story book than a rug after the tale that Martha told him about the red cloth. Then one day Mrs Tanner brought the little Misses Daisy and Muriel to see it spread out upon the floor, and Willie repeated the tale as well as he could remember it, then Daisy told him that the yellow velvet that formed the sun-flower had once been part of a costly robe belonging to her grandmother, and that it had been worn at court when her mamma was presented to the Queen. Mrs Tanner said with such a smart and illustrious rug in the room the bod and window needed smartening, so she went away, and presently returned with a red counterpane and a pair of small red curtains, which she arranged at the little window. Willie felt himself rich beyond all measure. He had got two suits of clothes, this nice room, and a little bookshelf to hold his books, besides £1 10s in the savings bank, for he never forgot his dream of the pretty cottage in the country, and his father working in the garden.

This latter part of the dream was not to come true, however, for Mr Grant had never recovered from the accident, and had all this while been in the hospital. He did not suffer much pain, but seemed to grow weaker and weaker, and took very little interest in anything beyond the visits which Annie and Willie paid him every Sunday, and those of the blind lady, who often went to see him during the week; and after these visits the nurse used to say he was happier than at any other time. At first he had been very morose and gloomy. "He was better where he was," he said. "People who couldn't control their actions were best under control. He had done nothing but harm all his life, and now he was out of the way of doing it."

To every cheering and encouraging word he shook his head. "He had spoiled his life, and spoiled the lives of his wife and children, and nothing would undo it." He had the well-known tale to tell of lost opportunity—lost respect, lost affection, through drink, then abandonment and degradation.

Annie had long since lost her resentment, for the wholesome moral atmosphere in which she lived gave no room for feelings of dislike. Mrs Payne little by little made her believe that her father was the greatest sufferer, and that no one but ourselves can really spoil our life, unless we will it to be spoiled. "Every error must be atoned for, and he is suffering more misery than he has ever made others suffer, and it is our privilege to comfort and help him. Let him believe that out of his evil god has come for you and your brother, and he will begin to understand what God is."

The poor dying father looked on and wondered at the improvement in his children, and often blessed the Christ-like woman who had returned good for evil, and saw in the neglected children objects for pity and help. She did good like God does good, for the love of it, and not for any hope of reward, but was finding now in the daily comfort of Annie that a reward is sure to come. As she sat by the bedside of the dying man and talked to him, out of the fulness of her own heart, of the unfailing and great goodness of God, who allowed error for the sake of the lessons it taught and pitied the children he allowed to fall, he lost the bitterness of his regret, and grew to believe that this lesson of humiliation was needed to fit him for better things to be. Then when he could not rise from his bed he would lie and watch the clouds float over the sky, and the stars come out, and every day the belief grew stronger that somewhere near them and him the young wife, whose loss had left him always lonely, was watching him, and that soon he would be talking to her face to face.

Then came the last night of all, and Mrs Payne and his children stood near his bed. Earlier in the evening he had talked to them and thanked them for their love, and commended the children to their blind friend, and to Annie he had said, "Serve her not with your hands alone, dear, but with your heart all the days of your life."

Then he seemed to sleep, a peaceful smile upon his face. The smile grew brighter, and he opened his eyes, and said softly in a tone of great joy, "Mary!" then the eyes closed again, and after the children had kissed him Mrs Payne would have led them away, but Willie threw himself upon the bed and cried out passionately:

"Daddy, come back. Mother has got God, and I want you. Oh, daddy, I was growing up so fast and saving up all my money, and now you've gone away!"

With tears streaming down her own face the blind lady sought to comfort him, telling him God had taken his father.

In the cold grey morning the children went home. Annie wept at her work silently, but Willie's eyes were dry. He pretended to be very busy all that day, and towards evening Mr Tanner sought him, and found him brushing away at his boots absently, with a pale pinched little face like the face he had first seen when the boy came to ask him for work, almost two years ago. The white face and large pathetic eyes went to the man's heart, and he said kindly, laying his hand upon the boy's shoulder:

"Put those boots down, sonny—they are bright enough, old man—and come up into your room. The cook has sent you up some soup."

Willie washed his hands and followed his master, and sat down by his table to eat the soup, while Mr Tanner seated himself upon the bed, wishing he could say something to comfort the lad, for Mrs Tanner had told him that he had not cried and grieved like a child, but had worked hard all day, with an absent look upon his face, and cool, weeping had said: "Lord, I can't bear to see him! When I asked him to come in for dinner he just said 'No, thank you, cook. I shan't want any dinner to-day, thank you,' just as though he had done living."

He sipped his soup now mechanically out of the habit of obedience to his master. When he had done Mr Tanner walked to the neat bookshelf and said:—"You must have some more books, sonny. These have all been well read."

"No thank you, sir," replied the boy, his eyes looking somewhere afar off. "I don't think I want any."

"Not want any books! Come, you have only just begun to read."

"Books," said Willie, "all tell you about how to live, so to be great when you are grown up."

"Just so, that's just it, and you are to become rich, and I am to come to dinner, remember."

"I don't think," replied the boy, "I want

jection when by signs she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat.

They reached Santa Barbara across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr S. L. Shaw, now 80 years old, and yet living there, riding a horse. She had never seen or heard of any object like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterwards the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed San Nicolas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race for ever.

Wild dogs had eaten her child. Her dress of blue and red feathers, a wonderful creation of barbaric hands, were sent to the Pope of Rome. Relic hunters have gathered mortars, pestles, toy steatite, canoes, and other curious things there for some years past, and shipped them to various Eastern and European museums. Skeletons and parts of skeletons have also been collected in large numbers, but to-day the bones of thousands of Indians are scattered about there. Some lie face down, indicating that they have fallen in battle. There are so many human relics there that San Nicolas is known as the "Isle of Skulls."

"The lonely island, whose highest part is but 1040ft above the sea," said a resident of Ventura, "is noted for the high artistic class of many of its relics. Had the woman rescued, then 52 years old, not died, a story passing strange would no doubt have been told of the race so long hemmed in by the waste of waters about. As it is, much of the story is shrouded in mystery for ever"